Conclusion

How have Indians and Chinese regarded each other historically, and how do they see each other's contemporary politics, society, and culture? The data, admittedly, is scarce, and so this chapter of the book rests on far more impressionistic evidence. Nonetheless, it does tell us a story about how Indians and Chinese assess each other. The broad conclusion is that they have gone from a respectful relationship in ancient times to a less respectful view of each other in modern and contemporary times. This may well reflect two changes: increasing communication and, at the same time, incomplete knowledge of each other; and the border conflict and power asymmetry between them.

Until the nineteenth century, India and China had limited contact. Buddhism was a point of engagement, but the spread of the faith to ordinary Chinese was a Sinicized version and did not lead to a terribly intimate relationship between the two 'heartlands'. Trade as well as social and cultural interactions between Indians and Chinese in other places such as Southeast Asia certainly was a bridge between the two societies after Buddhism declined in significance, but it was British imperialism in the nineteenth century that reconnected the two, mostly in negative ways related to the opium trade and the creation of foreign enclaves in China. It is in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries, with modern technologies of communication and travel, the spread of mass media, and public education, that the two peoples at large have become more aware of each other. Even then, the extent of mutual understanding has been quite thin. It also seems to have complicated the relationship. In 1709, the British poet Alexander Pope wrote: 'A little learning is a dangerous thing'. Pope's insight applied to India–China interactions is not that the two societies should know each other less but rather the opposite. Yet the signs are they are increasingly looking elsewhere for inspiration and edification.